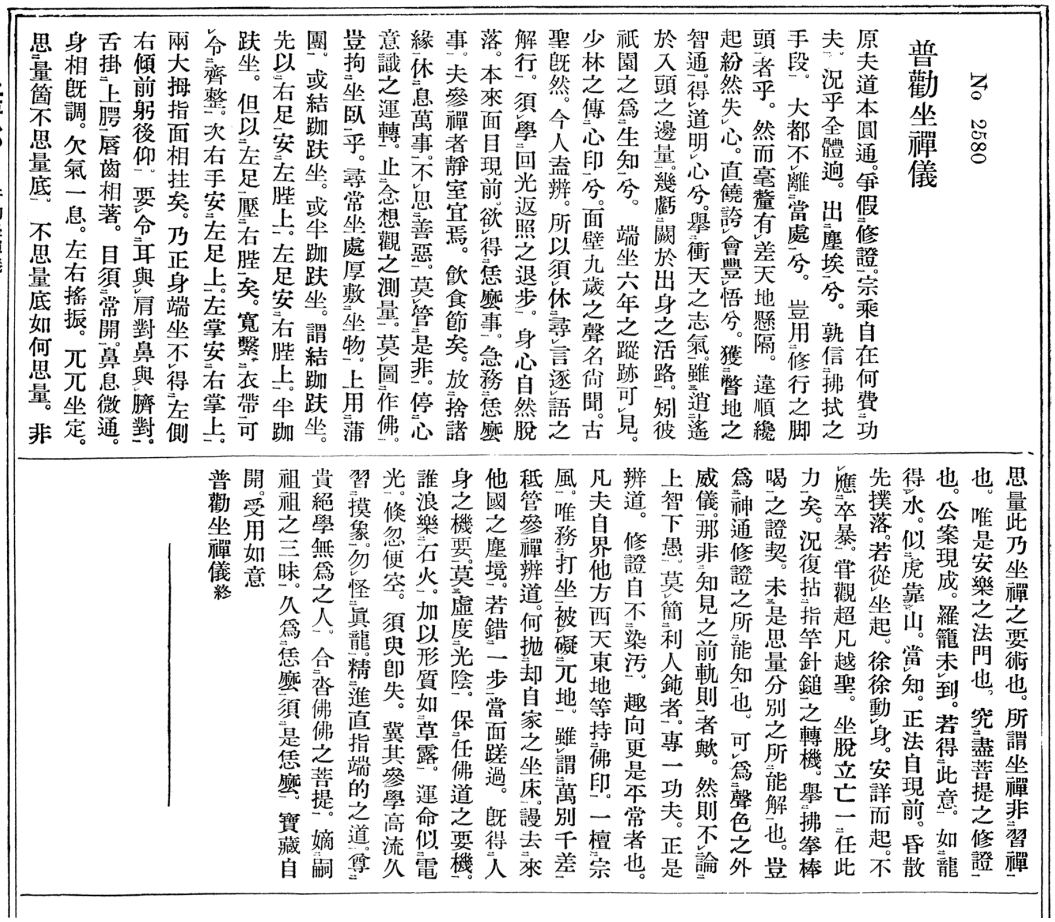
This is an excerpt from *Making Arrangement: Katagiri Roshi's Teachings on Fukanzazengi, Zen Master Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen*. We'll be working with the first part of this study guide in the Summer Buddhist Studies Course at Compassionate Ocean, June 10 - July 29, 2026. For details and to register visit https://www.oceanzen.org/buddhist-studies

## Manuscript



No 2580

普勸坐禪儀

原夫道本圓通。爭假修證。宗乘自在何費功夫。況乎全體逈。出塵埃兮。孰信拂拭之手段。大都不離當處兮。豈用修行之脚頭者乎。然而毫釐有差天地懸隔。違順纔起紛然失心。直饒誇會豐悟兮。獲瞥地之智通。得道明心兮。擧衝天之志氣。雖遒遙於入頭之邊量。幾虧闕於出身之活路。矧彼祇園之爲生知兮。端坐六年之蹤跡可見。少林之傳心印兮。面壁九歲之聲名尚聞。古聖既然。今人盍辨。所以須休尋言逐語之解行。須學回光返照之退步。身心自然脫落。本來面目現前。欲得恁麼事。急務恁麼事。夫參禪者靜室宜焉。飲食節矣。放捨諸緣休息萬事。不思善惡。莫管是非。停心意識之運轉。止念想觀之測量。莫圖作佛。豈拘坐臥乎。尋常坐處厚敷坐物。上用蒲團。或結跏趺坐。或半跏趺坐。謂結跏趺坐。先以右足安左胜上。左足安右胜上。半跏趺坐。但以左足壓右胜矣。寬繫衣帶可令齊整。次右手安左足上。左掌安右掌上。兩大拇指面相拄矣。乃正身端坐不得左側右傾前躬後仰。要令耳與肩對鼻與臍對。舌掛上腭。唇齒相著。目須常開。鼻息微通。身相既調。欠氣一息。左右搖振。兀兀坐定。思量箇不思量底。不思量底如何思量。非思量此乃坐禪之要術也。所謂坐禪非習禪也。唯是安樂之法門也。究盡菩提之修證也。公案現成。羅籠未到。若得此意。如龍得水。似虎靠山。當知。正法自現前。昏散先撲落。若從坐起。徐徐動身。安詳而起。不應卒暴。嘗觀超凡越聖。坐脫立亡一任此力矣。況復拈指竿針鎚之轉機。擧拂拳棒喝之證契。未是思量分別之所能解也。豈爲神通修證之所能知也。可爲聲色之外威儀。那非知見之前軌則者歟。然則不論上智下愚。莫簡利人鈍者。專一功夫。正是辨道。修證自不染汚。趣向更是平常者也。凡夫自界他方西天東地等持佛印。一檀宗風。唯務打坐。被礙兀地。雖謂萬別千差。秖管參禪辨道。何拋却自家之坐床。謾去來他國之塵境。若錯一步。當面蹉過。既得人身之機要。莫虛度光陰。保任佛道之要機。誰浪樂石火。加以形質如草露。運命似電光。倏忽便空。須臾即失。冀其參學高流久習摸象。勿怪眞龍。精進直指端的之道。尊貴絶學無爲之人。合沓佛佛之菩提。嫡嗣祖祖之三昧。久爲恁麼。須是恁麼。寶藏自開。受用如意

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Figure 1: The *Rufu-bon* ("Popular Version") of *Fukanzazengi*. The text is in Classical Chinese; the characters are read in vertical lines from right to left, with two blocks of text, top and bottom. Source: The Taishō Tripiṭaka, SAT Daizōkyō Text Database, Volume 82, Text 2580. Via dharmawanderer.wordpress.com.

## Translation

**Fukan Zazengi** (Universally Recommended Instructions for Zazen)

The way is originally perfect and all-pervading. How could it be contingent on practice and realization? The true vehicle is self-sufficient. What need is there for special effort? Indeed, the whole body is free from dust. Who could believe in a means to brush it clean? It is never apart from this very place; what is the use of traveling around to practice?

And yet, if there is a hairsbreadth deviation, it is like the gap between heaven and earth. If the least like or dislike arises, the mind is lost in confusion. Suppose you are confident in your understanding and rich in enlightenment, gaining the wisdom that knows at a glance, attaining the Way and clarifying the mind, arousing an aspiration to reach for the heavens. You are playing in the entranceway, but you are still short of the vital path of emancipation.

Consider the Buddha: although he was wise at birth, the traces of his six years of upright sitting can yet be seen. As for Bodhidharma, although he had received the mind-seal, his nine years of facing a wall is celebrated still. If even the ancient sages were like this, how can we today dispense with wholehearted practice?

Therefore, put aside the intellectual practice of investigating words and chasing phrases, and learn to take the backward step that turns the light and shines it inward. Body and mind of themselves will drop away, and your original face will manifest. If you want to realize such, get to work on such right now.

For practicing Zen, a quiet room is suitable. Eat and drink moderately. Put aside all involvements and suspend all affairs. Do not think "good" or "bad." Do not judge true or false. Give up the operations of mind, intellect, and consciousness; stop measuring with thoughts, ideas, and views. Have no designs on becoming a buddha. How could that be limited to sitting or lying down?

At your sitting place, spread out a thick mat and put a cushion on it. Sit either in the full-lotus or half-lotus position. In the full-lotus position, first place your right foot on your left thigh, then your left foot on your right thigh. In the half-lotus, simply place your left foot on your right thigh. Tie

your robes loosely and arrange them neatly. Then place your right hand on your left leg and your left hand on your right palm, thumb-tips lightly touching. Straighten your body and sit upright, leaning neither left nor right, neither forward nor backward. Align your ears with your shoulders and your nose with your navel. Rest the tip of your tongue against the front of the roof of your mouth, with teeth together and lips shut. Always keep your eyes open, and breathe softly through your nose.

Once you have adjusted your posture, take a breath and exhale fully, rock your body right and left, and settle into steady, immovable sitting. Think of not thinking, "Not thinking –what kind of thinking is that?" Nonthinking. This is the essential art of zazen.

The zazen I speak of is not meditation practice. It is simply the dharma gate of joyful ease, the practice realization of totally culminated enlightenment. It is the koan realized; traps and snares can never reach it. If you grasp the point, you are like a dragon gaining the water, like a tiger taking to the mountains. For you must know that the true dharma appears of itself, so that from the start dullness and distraction are struck aside.

When you arise from sitting, move slowly and quietly, calmly and deliberately. Do not rise suddenly or abruptly. In surveying the past, we find that transcendence of both mundane and sacred, and dying while either sitting or standing, have all depended entirely on the power of zazen.

In addition, triggering awakening with a finger, a banner, a needle, or a mallet, and effecting realization with a whisk, a fist, a staff, or a shout –these cannot be understood by discriminative thinking; much less can they be known through the practice of supernatural power. They must represent conduct beyond seeing and hearing. Are they not a standard prior to knowledge and views?

This being the case, intelligence or lack of it is not an issue; make no distinction between the dull and the sharp-witted. If you concentrate your effort single-mindedly, that in itself is wholeheartedly engaging the way. Practice-realization is naturally undefiled. Going forward is, after all, an everyday affair.

In general, in our world and others, in both India and China, all equally hold the buddha-seal. While each lineage expresses its own style, they are all simply devoted to sitting, totally blocked in resolute stability. Although they say that there are ten thousand distinctions and a thousand varia-

tions, they just wholeheartedly engage the way in zazen. Why leave behind the seat in your own home to wander in vain through the dusty realms of other lands? If you make one misstep, you stumble past what is directly in front of you.

You have gained the pivotal opportunity of human form. Do not pass your days and nights in vain. You are taking care of the essential activity of the buddha-way. Who would take wasteful delight in the spark from a flintstone? Besides, form and substance are like the dew on the grass, the fortunes of life like a dart of lightning –emptied in an instant, vanished in a flash.

Please, honored followers of Zen, long accustomed to groping for the elephant, do not doubt the true dragon. Devote your energies to the way of direct pointing at the real. Revere the one who has gone beyond learning and is free from effort. Accord with the enlightenment of all the buddhas; succeed to the samadhi of all the ancestors. Continue to live in such a way, and you will be such a person. The treasure store will open of itself, and you may enjoy it freely.

– Source: sotozen.com

# Chapter 1: Universal Recommendation for Zazen

## Title

普勸坐禪儀
*Fukan zazen gi*

Universally Recommended Instructions for Zazen [SZ]

Universal Promotion of the Principles of Zazen [EB]

Universal Recommendation for Zazen [KR]

## Commentary

Katagiri Roshi explains the term *zazen*:

> *Zazen* [is] Zen meditation: in Japanese *za zen* (坐禪). *Za* (坐) is "sitting." *Zen* (禪) is zen, "tranquility."
>
> I always use the term *zazen*, because the zazen we do is a little different from the meditation that [...] other religions do. That's why I want to use the original term *zazen*.
>
> In Chinese, etymologically, the *za* [is that] two persons sit in the universe. (*Transcriber's Note:* The character *za* 坐 depicts two people 人 sitting on the ground or earth 土.) [...] That [indicates that] you have to sit with more than two beings, [and] not only human beings; you cannot sit alone. So you should sit with more than two beings on the earth, in the universe – not in your own egoistic, selfish territory.
>
> [If] you must open yourself and sit in the universe, very naturally you have to sit *with* all sentient beings. That is called *sitting*. And then very naturally [...] *that* sitting is exactly *zen*, tranquility – because all sentient beings around you are exactly sitting with you! So very naturally that is called *zen*: tranquility.
>
> So you, and the universe, earth, all beings, and all circumstances, [...] become sitting with you, together. This is called *zazen*. All we have to do

> is to do our best to sit in the universe with all sentient beings. That's *all* we have to do.
>
> – From "Katagiri Roshi's Zazen Instruction" (1981).

This was how Katagiri Roshi introduced *zazen* to a small group of people in 1981. Note that almost the very first thing he talks about is not a technical explanation, nor an individual goal, but that we sit with all beings, and not just human beings.

This point will come up again, frequently. And we'll return to the definition of zen as *tranquility* in Chapter 12: "Surrender to Tranquility."

Katagiri Roshi says about sitting down in *zazen*:

> *Anyone* can do it. Even if you are not Buddhist, or even if you cannot come [to the Zen Center], you can sit down. [...] This is *shikantaza* (whole-hearted sitting). [...] This is *freedom* – open to *everybody*! No exceptions.
>
> That's why Dōgen Zenji says "Universal Recommendation for Zazen" – *universal* recommendation. It's really *universal*. [It's] not only weeding out (that is, removing all weeds) on your own territory. Anyone can do it. Wherever you may be, you can do it.
>
> – From "*Fukanzazengi*: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3," June 11, 1979, at 1:02:07.

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What does Katagiri Roshi mean when he says that zazen is not only removing all the weeds on our own territory?

By "weeds," Katagiri Roshi means any mental or physical conditions that we don't like. We can also understand weeds as *karma* – a topic that we will return to – but again, weeds are the kind of karma that we don't like. Katagiri Roshi says:

> According to a narrow understanding of human life, first you cut off the root of your weeds, [then] you want to be happy. That's nice... but it is a narrow understanding. Because you cannot completely cut off the weeds. You cannot destroy weeds. Weeds grow any time, anywhere.
>
> So the important point is arrangement of our circumstances: how to use the weeds. Even the weeds are nothing but being, which is helping all sentient beings.

> – From "Fukanzazengi: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 1" (June 9, 1979) at 56:36.

So zazen is not about eliminating mental or physical states that we don't like. Nor, in fact, is it about chasing after mental states that we *do* like. Instead, zazen is about arranging our circumstances – our environment, and our body and mind – so that we can sit *with* all sentient beings.

But what do we mean by "all sentient beings"? This is actually a deep question. In brief, as we will see, "all sentient beings" means *everything*. Sitting with all sentient beings means sitting in the midst of everything that we are experiencing. That, in turn, means sitting in the midst of the total dynamic working of the whole universe.

This is what Katagiri Roshi means by "not only on our own territory." Zazen is not a kind of meditation where we are attempting to cut ourselves off from this world and its difficulties.

Plainly speaking, this is a different understanding than in some varieties of Buddhism. We will explore this topic in more detail as we go on, especially in Chapter 20: "Dullness and Distraction are Struck Aside."

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But because zazen is just sitting down and being present, that means *anyone* can do this practice. In other words, it is *universal*. Here is how Katagiri Roshi sums up the practice of *shikantaza* (wholehearted sitting), which is the kind of zazen we do:

> So, *shikantaza* is arrangement of all things, and then sit down. That's all.
>
> This is really *bodhisattva* practice, to help all sentient beings. If you practice this, your life is really helpful, for you and for others. It is very true. Even though you don't say [anything], somebody realizes. You have something to tell him or her.
>
> So that is *shikantaza* – the zazen you do, mentioned by Buddha. It's pretty difficult for us to understand intellectually, because we are getting the use of always analyzing and synthesizing everything in the dualistic world; it's very difficult to *stop immediately*. That's why even though you stop for a while, you don't appreciate that practice. But this practice is [...] the best way.
>
> We can explain how important this kind of [Buddhist] practice is philosophically, psychologically – but it takes time. That is a huge world, the

> philosophical background, psychological background. But even though you don't know [it], you can do it – right now, right here. This is a very urgent need; we have to do it. Whoever you are, wherever you may be, you can do it.
>
> For instance, if you are in an office – well still you can do it. If there is no one there, you can sit down in a chair and calm yourself. If you are talking with somebody, you can realize a certain pause, where no words come up. For that time, you can return to yourself, and breathe.
>
> You can do it, okay? Wherever you may go. It's really universal. It's very simple. It's *too* simple to realize. But, this is the best way. Not only for your life in *this* world, but in the next life, in the life after next life, after next next life, continually.
>
> – From "*Fukanzazengi*: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3" (June 11, 1979) at 1:09:51.

This is a small part of a much longer talk which ties together many ideas in *Fukanzazengi*, including this notion of practicing for lifetime after lifetime, and what it means to arrange our circumstances. We'll return to those points in the following chapters.

But this is the conclusion: you can do it. Whatever your situation, whether you understand it or not, you can do zazen. This is a *universal* way to benefit both yourself and the entire cosmic situation.